

LEARNING TO SPEAK

DELHI



Our very own Babel

Move over French and German, it's time to make space for Indian languages as two youngsters reach out for their roots

■ By **Bushra Ahmed**

The students are bent over their books. They frown occasionally as they stumble upon an unfamiliar word. Suddenly one of them breaks into a Ghalib couplet in chaste Urdu, pronunciation and the lyrical lilt perfectly in place. The class applauds and many *wah wahs* follow as another gets up. This time it's a *rubayee* (couplet) by Omar Khayyam. Energetic repartee begins as the class bounces Urdu couplets back and forth, each trying to out-talk the other. Yet, Urdu isn't their mother tongue, but a language which they are learning in the voluntary language class of the Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) that takes place thrice a week and has students from different backgrounds, cultures and states. Their aim is to learn Urdu that will, at least for some, show the meaning of a culture alien to them.

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IS THE NUMBER OF LANGUAGES SPOKEN IN INDIA, ACCORDING TO THE 1991 CENSUS

For Neelambuj Singh, an M.Phil student from the Delhi University, whose mother tongue is Hindi, it's all about "the feel of it". The 23-year-old became fascinated with the language when he chanced upon the Urdu magazine *Kadambari*. "Urdu is a culture in itself, not just a script," he says. For Sheetanshu Kumar, 23, a native of Gorakhpur, Uttar Pradesh, the obsession is Bangla, a language he fell in love with during a brief stay in Kolkata. When he went to JNU for his M.Phil, he signed up for the online Bangla classes. He still remembers that moment when in Kolkata he had entered a class and a big, brawny student had asked him to *shor shor* (move over). He didn't know the meaning and it had resulted in quite a scuffle.

For Kumar and Singh, language is more than a one-way ticket to fast-rising careers. It is an intrinsic part of their lives, their way of reaching out to their country and how it speaks, in a multitude of tongues.



ROOT CAUSE:
Neelambuj (left)
and Sheetanshu

RAVI'S SAHANI